

The Last Bus

DIFFICULT PRACTICE

Name: _____

Date set: _____

Due: _____

OPENING — CONTINUE FROM HERE

The doors hissed shut behind me before I'd even found a seat, and for a moment the whole bus rocked with the force of it. Every other passenger had somewhere obvious to be — headphones in, eyes down, the particular stillness of people who have done this journey a thousand times. I hadn't. I'd got on because it was the only bus still running, and because the alternative was standing outside that house a minute longer than I already had.

Three stops later, someone sat down directly across the aisle from me and didn't look away.

— continue the story from this exact moment —

You are not starting from nothing. Match the voice and tense already set (first person, past tense) and keep it consistent throughout. Whatever happens next has to make sense of two things the opening already tells us: something happened at "that house," and someone on this bus already recognises the narrator.

TECHNIQUE REQUIRED

TENSION & PACE

Build tension gradually — don't reveal who the stranger is or what happened at the house in the first paragraph.

At least one short, punchy sentence (3–5 words) placed at a moment of realisation.

Vary sentence openings — no more than two sentences in a row starting with the same word type.

CHARACTER & VOICE

At least one line of internal thought showing the narrator's fear or suspicion, not just their actions.

Give the stranger one distinguishing physical detail that becomes significant later.

Include natural, unattributed dialogue at least once — let the reader work out who's speaking from context.

STRUCTURE

Resolve the "house" mystery by the end — even partially — don't leave it as pure cliffhanger.

At least one paragraph break used deliberately for dramatic effect, not just length.

LANGUAGE

One extended metaphor carried across at least two sentences (not a one-off simile).

Precise verbs throughout — avoid "walked," "said," "looked" where a more specific verb exists.

CHECKLIST — GO OVER IT AGAIN

1. **Tense and person stay consistent** — first person, past tense, throughout, including flashback moments.
2. Every "he/she/they" clearly refers back to a named character — no ambiguous pronouns.
3. Read the dialogue aloud — does it sound like something a real person would actually say?
4. **No unearned twist** — if the stranger turns out to be significant, the reader should be able to look back and see it was fair, not random.
5. Check paragraph lengths vary — not five paragraphs of identical length in a row.
6. Ending resolves or meaningfully changes the tension set up in the opening — it doesn't just stop.